

Vietnamese communists, whom they distrusted.

At the time of the coup, France briefly floated a proposal for an international conference that might secure Cambodian sovereignty and neutrality, but failed to get support from enough nations to make this a reality. Understandably angry and feeling betrayed, Sihanouk took refuge in Beijing. He made the surprising announcement that he was forming a coalition with the communists to “liberate our motherland.” In later years, he would defend this impetuous move as an effort to avenge himself against Lon Nol.



Peasant support

The Cambodian peasantry was overwhelmingly apolitical, but had royalist sympathies. After Sihanouk voiced his support for the Khmer Rouge, their numbers swelled from 6,000 to 50,000.

Responding to anarchy

Cambodia descended into a violent anarchy of rival gangs, Khmer Rouge guerrillas, and Vietnamese troops of various kinds grasping for advantage. Prompted by US officials in Phnom Penh, Lon Nol appealed for outside help, and the Nixon administration was more than ready to respond. But the Khmer Rouge was also ready to make a “recruiting sergeant” of the misery caused by continued US and Vietnamese incursions.

“The **Khmer Rouge** [should] realize that their existence **depends** on ours ... Cambodia is **our staging area.**”

A VIET CONG DOCUMENT, CAPTURED IN APRIL 1970